

5.1 Introduction

“Security” used to be a synonymous with anti-virus software. Till just a little over a decade ago, most data transfers involved a floppy disk, and activating a virus scan every time a floppy was accessed ensured that a user’s PC remained virus-free. Then the Net exploded.

We don’t need to tell you what the Net is like today: “security” covers a lot more than just viruses. The threats facing a lay Net user include rootkits, browser hijackers, phishers, worms, Trojans, keyloggers, data sniffers, and more. And for a system to be termed secure, all these bases need to be covered.

Unlike the anti-virus packages of yesteryear, it is nowadays common to come across Security Suites—bundles consisting of an anti-virus, a firewall, and anti-spyware in one package.

5.2 Terminology

Here we talk about some essential terms associated with security.

5.2.1. Phishing

This refers to the practice of making a user part with sensitive financial and other personal details by posing as an authorised agent. Usually, this takes the form of an e-mail asking the user to update details at a bank or company Web page, the link to which is provided. The Web page looks just like the original, and a gullible user might enter the requested details, like username and password, to log into his account. These details are routed to the scammer who then misuses it at the real site, sometimes at the same time.

5.2.2. Rootkits

This type of application burst into the public consciousness after it was found that Sony had been using this technique to hide its anti-piracy applications from showing up. Rootkits are applications that can hide other applications from showing up in any of the system’s monitors. By inserting rootkits, it is possible for malware to avoid detection even by anti-virus applications.